

# THEATRE OF SPORT, CHENNAI STYLE

*Sportstar* correspondents capture the sights, sounds, and emotions from Chennai's Pro Kabaddi League leg — a city where fans cheer effort as much as victory, and every match **unfolds like theatre.**

**C**hennai has a unique contract with sport: give your all, and the city will give you its heart, win or lose.

We saw it when the crowd at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium applauded Pakistan's players after the 1999 Test win, acknowledging the quality of cricket above all rivalry. And we saw it again in 2023, when the fans welcomed Afghanistan's win over Pakistan with the same generosity of spirit.

That same affection has now extended into the kabaddi arena, as the city played host to the Pro Kabaddi League (PKL) from September 29.

Even on nights when Tamil Thalaivas — the home team — wasn't on the roster, the SDAT Multipurpose Indoor Stadium was packed to

capacity. Fans had to wait a couple of days to watch their side in action, and when the time came, they turned up in force.

Led by the experienced Arjun Deshwal, the Thalaivas took on U Mumba in the first game of the Chennai leg. Supporters began streaming in nearly two hours before the starting whistle, armed with banners, jerseys, and *parai* drums — a sound unmistakably Tamil, reverberating through the venue.

Of all the teams, the Thalaivas drew the loudest cheer. The energy was palpable from the moment they stepped on the mat. When Arjun went in for his first raid, the roar hit 119 dB (**facing page, below**) — Chennai had made its presence felt.

One fan slipped past security to rush onto the mat, attempting to touch Arjun's feet — a gesture that

captured how personal this connection has become. The atmosphere wasn't merely supportive; it was electric.

Despite Arjun's efforts and the defenders' resilience, U Mumba proved too strong on the night, handing the Thalaivas a tough defeat. Yet, instead of silence or jeers, the capacity crowd rose as one, applauding their team long after the final whistle. It was the sort of ovation only Chennai seems capable of — a reminder that here, kabaddi has found a home.

**Nigamanth P.**

## **Where sport meets stagecraft**

The first thing that strikes a visitor upon entering the SDAT Multipurpose Indoor Stadium in the late evening for a PKL match is the scale of the lighting rig. The mat itself is not